

Aristea of the Shifting Tides

Level 17-25 Optimization and Advancement Guide



Tide. Frost. Form. Arcane craftsmanship.

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Aristea should finish Arcane Trickster before returning to Wizard. Her verified level-17 chassis is **Exploiter Wizard 9 / Crossblooded Wildblooded Sorcerer 1 / Arcane Trickster 7**, not Wizard 17. Arcane Trickster 8 immediately grants another sneak-attack die and advances her Wizard casting to 17th level, unlocking 9th-level spells. Arcane Trickster 9 adds Invisible Thief, and Arcane Trickster 10 adds another sneak-attack die plus Surprise Spells. No other ordinary three-level sequence advances her signature ray engine and full arcane casting this efficiently.

The primary progression is:

- 1. **Level 18: Arcane Trickster 8.** Gain 9th-level Wizard spells and raise total sneak attack, including the artifact, from 11d6 to 12d6.
- 2. **Level 19: Arcane Trickster 9.** Gain Invisible Thief and Tricky Spells 5/day. Take Quicken Spell unless a campaign feature already supplies it as a permanent feat.
- 3. **Level 20: Arcane Trickster 10.** Gain Surprise Spells and raise total sneak attack to 13d6.
- 4. **Levels 21-25: return to Exploiter Wizard 10-14** unless the campaign has an approved epic Arcane Trickster table that continues both casting and sneak attack.
- 5. Preserve the Benthic, Merciful, Sap Master, and multi-ray campaign engine while adding a dependable method of attacking genuinely flat-footed opponents.
- 6. Treat all shark references on the Hero Lab sheet as placeholders for Aristea's canonical narwhal Animal Lord form.

This guide assumes Aristea is recovered from Tartarus before advancement is applied. Her rescue remains a narrative prerequisite, not a reason to postpone mechanical planning.

Verified level-17 build

The current Hero Lab sheet supplied on 22 July 2026 establishes the following starting point.

Category	Current state
Character level	17
Class split	Exploiter Wizard 9 / Crossblooded Wildblooded Sorcerer 1 / Arcane Trickster 7
Effective Wizard spellcasting	16th level from Wizard 9 + Arcane Trickster 7
Highest Wizard spell level	8th
Race and template	Mythic half-elf Animal Lord; Hero Lab uses Shoreborn/shark as a narwhal placeholder
Alignment and deity	Neutral good; devotee of Nereus
Intelligence	34 on the supplied sheet
Signature spell	Scorching ray
Listed sneak attack	+6d6
Artifact correction	Additional +5d6 sneak attack, for an actual current total of +11d6
Primary roles	Ray striker, water-and-cold controller, shapeshifter, healer, primary crafter, merchant-mage
Campaign status	Dead with soul imprisoned in Tartarus; body survived

The sheet is displayed while Aristea is Huge and shows mature-adult bronze-dragon natural attacks, apparently reflecting an active transformation. Do not treat Strength 55, Huge size, dragon natural attacks, or similar displayed combat-form statistics as her unmodified body.

Current feats and abilities that must not be recommended again

The sheet already contains:

- Benthic Spell

- Empower Spell
- Maximize Spell
- Merciful Spell
- Piercing Spell
- Sap Adept
- Sap Master
- Spell Perfection (scorching ray)
- Mythic Spell Lore
- Mythic Crafter
- Eldritch Heritage (Mythic)
- Healer's Hands, Incredible Healer, Signature Skill (Heal)
- Extra Arcanist Exploit
- Arcane Builder (wondrous items)
- Scribe Scroll

It also lists free campaign implementations of Power Attack, Combat Expertise, and Deadly Aim. Do not spend future feat slots on any of these options.

Current casting and exploit package

The sheet confirms an Arcane Reservoir, Quick Study, Bloodline Development, School Understanding, and other Exploiter Wizard functions. It also lists the Arcane and Shapechanger bloodline arcanas, Blood Havoc, Metamagic Adept, Mutable Flesh, and Arcane Apotheosis through her Sorcerer/bloodline package and supporting abilities.

Her prepared spells already include heavily modified scorching rays, greater dispel magic, enervation, greater invisibility, particulate form, temporal divergence, greater teleport, form of the dragon III, moment of prescience, and temporal stasis. Advancement should broaden this functioning engine rather than rebuild it.

Canonical corrections to Hero Lab

Narwhal Animal Lord

Hero Lab could not select narwhal and therefore prints shark-specific abilities such as Change Shape (Shark), Charm Animal (Sharks Only), and Speak with Animal (Sharks Only). Those entries are implementation placeholders, not campaign canon.

Aristea's sacred form is a narwhal. Her established themes include arctic-sea endurance, a spiraled horn used as an arcane focus, calming lesser sea creatures, and sonar-like perception of disturbances in deep water. Exact mechanical substitutions for the shark abilities should be maintained on a manual adjustment sheet until the GM supplies a final narwhal stat block.

Artifact sneak attack

Hero Lab displays Sneak Attack +6d6 but cannot represent the artifact's additional +5d6. All planning and damage calculations must therefore begin at **11d6**, not 6d6.

The artifact's sneak-attack dice increase whenever an attack qualifies for sneak attack. They do not by themselves make an opponent eligible for sneak attack or flat-footed.

Campaign ray ruling

The campaign allows Aristea's rays to apply sneak attack in the established manner. The guide calculates the signature routine using the campaign's multi-ray ruling rather than applying it generically to other characters.

The Benthic/Merciful/Sap interaction is likewise a campaign ruling. Published Sap Adept and Sap Master refer to a bludgeoning weapon; the campaign treats the Benthic ray as qualifying. Preserve that distinction whenever the build is discussed outside this campaign.

Signature damage engine

The intended attack is a Benthic, Merciful scorching ray against a flat-footed opponent, enhanced by Sap Adept, Sap Master, Spell Perfection, and selected metamagic.

Sneak-attack progression

Character level	Class	Listed/class sneak attack	Artifact	Actual total	Sap Master dice	Sap Adept bonus per qualifying attack
17	Arcane Trickster 7	6d6	5d6	11d6	22d6	+11
18	Arcane Trickster 8	7d6	5d6	12d6	24d6	+12
19	Arcane Trickster 9	7d6	5d6	12d6	24d6	+12
20	Arcane Trickster 10	8d6	5d6	13d6	26d6	+13

With three qualifying rays and the campaign's multi-ray ruling, the sneak component alone becomes:

Level	Three-ray sneak component before normal spell damage
17	66d6 + 33 nonlethal
18-19	72d6 + 36 nonlethal
20+	78d6 + 39 nonlethal

These totals exclude the rays' ordinary damage, Empower or Maximize effects, Blood Havoc, the artifact's separate Vital Strike-like effect, critical hits, vulnerability, and other bonuses. Recalculate from the table ruling before multiplying any component: sneak attack is not automatically multiplied by every effect that multiplies spell damage.

The flat-footed requirement

- Sap Master works only against a **flat-footed** opponent. Denying Dexterity to AC is not automatically the same condition.
- An enemy that has not yet acted at the start of combat is normally flat-footed. Aristea's +41 initiative makes the opening volley her most reliable Sap Master window.
 - Greater invisibility and Arcane Trickster 9's Invisible Thief normally deny Dexterity to AC, allowing sneak attack, but do not by themselves make the target flat-footed.
 - Impromptu Sneak Attack removes the target's Dexterity bonus against one attack, but does not by itself create the flat-footed condition.
 - Arcane Trickster 10's Surprise Spells also requires flat-footed targets.

If the GM has ruled that any of those effects counts as flat-footed in this campaign, record that ruling explicitly. Otherwise, invest in initiative, surprise, scouting, and a separate flat-footed enabler rather than assuming invisibility activates Sap Master.

Spell resistance and immunities

Piercing Spell is already owned. The next reliability layer is Spell Penetration followed by Greater Spell Penetration, unless the campaign's expected enemies rarely possess spell resistance. Against nonlethal immunity, precision-damage immunity, concealment, spell turning, or effects that prevent sneak attack, Aristea must switch to control, dispelling, or an alternate damage routine.

Corrected class progression

Levels 18-20: finish Arcane Trickster

Character level	Class level	Casting	Class gain	Advancement decision
18	Arcane Trickster 8	Effective Wizard 17; unlock 9th-level spells	Sneak attack increases by +1d6	Mandatory default choice
19	Arcane Trickster 9	Effective Wizard 18	Invisible Thief; Tricky Spells 5/day	Finish the near-capstone progression
20	Arcane Trickster 10	Effective Wizard 19	Sneak attack +1d6; Surprise Spells	Complete the prestige class

Arcane Trickster advances spell slots, caster level, and prepared Wizard spellcasting at every level. It does not advance Exploiter Wizard class features, but levels 8-10 are more valuable to this build than abandoning the prestige class three levels before its capstone.

Levels 21-25: published default

If there is no approved epic Arcane Trickster continuation, return to Exploiter Wizard.

Character level	Class	Effective Wizard casting	Main gain or focus
21	Exploiter Wizard 10	20	Wizard bonus feat; consolidate the core ray package
22	Exploiter Wizard 11	21	Continue caster-level and spellbook advancement under epic rules
23	Exploiter Wizard 12	22	Standard feat and infrastructure/control expansion
24	Exploiter Wizard 13	23	Gain the next Exploiter Wizard exploit if the archetype table applies normally
25	Exploiter Wizard 14	24	Standard feat; prepare for the campaign's level-10/11 spell thresholds

Epic Arcane Trickster alternative

Epic Arcane Trickster is preferable to Wizard 10-14 only if the approved table continues all three of the following:

- 1. full Wizard spellcasting at every level;
- 2. additional sneak-attack dice on a useful schedule; and
- 3. meaningful improvements to Surprise Spells, Invisible Thief, or related trickster abilities.

Do not invent Arcane Trickster 11+ by extrapolating the published ten-level table. Obtain the campaign's epic prestige-class progression first, compare it directly with Exploiter Wizard 10-14, and then replace levels 21-25 if it is superior.

Standard feat advancement

Aristea receives normal character feats at levels 19, 21, 23, and 25. Exploiter Wizard 10 should also provide a Wizard bonus feat unless the campaign's archetype implementation changes that feature.

Recommended order

Opportunity	Default selection	Reason
Level 19	Quicken Spell	Spell Perfection can apply Quicken to scorching ray without its normal slot increase; this creates exceptional action economy
Level 21	Spell Penetration	Doubles down on Piercing Spell and improves reliability against epic foes
Wizard 10 bonus	Dazing Spell, Rime Spell, or another legal metamagic feat	Wizard bonus feats do not normally include Greater Spell Penetration; use this slot for control or another metamagic tool
Level 23	Greater Spell Penetration	Completes the core resistance package
Level 25	Seeking Spell, if approved, or an epic prerequisite	Counters concealment and cover, or qualifies for the chosen epic spell table

Quicken Spell is the largest correction to the old feat plan. Aristea owns Spell Perfection but not Quicken Spell. Once Quicken is acquired, she can use Spell Perfection to make it free on scorching ray and use Magical Lineage plus Wayang Spellhunter to absorb other metamagic costs. Prepare exact legal slot combinations on the final sheet instead of assuming every metamagic modifier is simultaneously free.

Conditional alternatives

- **Spell Focus and Greater Spell Focus (evocation):** the sheet lists a Spell Focus Evocation item, not clearly the feat itself. Buy the feat only if the item does not satisfy prerequisites or cannot be relied upon.
- **Craft feats:** Mythic Crafting Mastery may already let Aristea count as possessing the required item-creation feats. Do not spend feats on Craft Staff or Craft Wondrous Item until the exact ability text is checked.
- **Improved Initiative:** normally excellent for Sap Master, but +41 initiative is already overwhelming. Take it only if equal-tier enemies routinely beat her initiative.
- **Spell Specialization (scorching ray):** provides little damage after the spell has reached three rays; use it only if its doubled Spell Perfection interaction or caster-level checks are specifically valuable at the table.
- **Rime Spell:** use with cold spells for battlefield control; it is not part of the Benthic scorching-ray damage core.

Mythic advancement

Verified existing mythic choices

The current sheet lists:

- Mythic Spell Lore
- Mythic Crafter
- Eldritch Heritage (Mythic)
- Hard to Kill
- Surge 1d6
- Crafting Mastery
- Idealize
- Warlord Reborn
- Superior Transformation

The sheet does not provide a clean current tier/path summary, and campaign Mythic Tier is calculated from godly powers and unlocked mythic path powers. Reconcile these entries with the campaign formula before assigning the next tier.

Next path-power priorities

Priority	Ability	Purpose
1	Wild Arcana	Provides an unprepared arcane answer when the prepared list is wrong for the encounter
2	Eldritch Breach	Rolls twice for spell resistance and dispel-related caster-level checks; ideal against mythic defenses
3	Arcane Metamastery	Supplies situational metamagic without rebuilding daily preparation
4	Channel Power	High-tier damage multiplier for a decisive ray or area spell
5	Mythic Spellpower	Expands the mythic spell portfolio after reliability is established
6	Arcanist's Escape or equivalent	Emergency extraction when grappled, pinned, entangled, or magically contained

Do not purchase an option already granted through the sheet's bloodline, artifact, or campaign mythic implementation. Action economy is especially important: verify whether a new power competes with Quicken Spell, Arcane Reservoir use, immediate defenses, or mythic expenditure.

Next mythic-feat priorities

Priority	Mythic feat	Reason
1	Spell Penetration (Mythic)	Most direct improvement against mythic spell resistance after the base feat is taken
2	Seeking Spell (Mythic), if approved	Improves the ranged-touch delivery system against cover and concealment
3	Extra Mythic Power	Fuels flexible casting, penetration, emergency movement, and burst abilities
4	Spell Focus (Mythic) - Evocation	Improves control and damaging evocations after touch accuracy and resistance are solved
5	Rime Spell (Mythic), if approved	Adds flexible cold-based movement control

Every purchased mythic feat also contributes one Mythic Power point under the campaign rules. Apply the escalating Boon cost for purchased mythic feats and do not count a feat twice if another feature grants it.

Spendable Boons and Nereus

Deific Obedience boons and the campaign's spendable Boons are separate systems.

Spendable Boon order

1. Confirm the current Animal Lord template tier and the exact manual narwhal replacement.
2. Upgrade Animal Lord only if the next tier materially improves the narwhal form, spellcasting in transformed form, senses, or naval operations.
3. Purchase Spell Penetration (Mythic) and Seeking Spell (Mythic) only after their base feats are secured and the escalating mythic-feat Boon cost is acceptable.
4. Save five Boons for adoption by Nereus if Aristea wants Nereus as divine bloodline rather than only patron.
5. Save another five for demigod status if adoption and campaign story support it.
6. Treat Mortal God as a later ten-Boon objective.

Each new godly power is unusually efficient because it grants one Mythic Tier and two Mythic Power points under the campaign formula. Choose powers that improve spell access, action economy, water/cold control, transformation, or survivability before purchasing redundant raw damage.

Deific Obedience direction

If Nereus lacks a dedicated printed obedience, use Gozreh's sea-oriented boons only as a power-ceiling model and obtain GM approval for the adaptation. Favor protection from energy, deep-water survival, weather or current control, and a greater water elemental ally. Do not count the Animal Lord template as an obedience boon unless the GM explicitly connects the systems.

Spell acquisition and preparation

Immediate 9th-level spellbook order at level 18

1. **Time stop:** establishes buffs, movement, walls, summons, and escape before enemies can respond.
2. **Shapechange:** the best broad transformation tool and a natural extension of Aristea's identity.
3. **Mass icy prison:** thematic, encounter-scale control when enemies are vulnerable to cold and restraint.
4. **Wish:** emergency problem solving, recovery, and access to lower-level effects not prepared.
5. **Mage's disjunction:** reserve answer to extreme magical defenses when destroying loot or allied magic is acceptable.
6. **Foresight:** long-duration protection against being caught flat-footed and a strong defense on a high-value caster.
7. **Teleportation circle:** strategic movement for the party, crews, and infrastructure.

Do not prepare only 9th-level attack spells. Aristea's perfected lower-level ray already supplies efficient damage; her highest slots should solve encounters that damage cannot.

Signature ray preparation

Maintain at least three prepared tiers:

- a low-slot Benthic, Empowered, Merciful, Piercing scorching ray for efficient qualifying targets;
- a higher-slot burst version using Maximize or Quicken as the encounter demands;
- a minimally modified or alternate-energy version for enemies immune to nonlethal damage or resistant to the primary routine.

After taking Quicken Spell, document the exact Spell Perfection choice and final slot for every standard ray package. Spell Perfection makes one metamagic feat free per casting; Magical Lineage and Wayang Spellhunter reduce remaining adjustments, but they do not make every combination automatically legal.

Flat-footed setup and scouting

- Use exceptional initiative, stealth, advance scouting, divination, and coordinated surprise to make the first volley count.
- Prepare contingency and immediate defenses before exposing Aristea for the opening ray.
- Coordinate with Demidius to identify and remove spell turning, concealment, immunity, and resistance before firing.
- Ask allies to supply an effect that explicitly causes the flat-footed condition if the encounter survives the opening round.

Control and naval magic

Prioritize:

- icy prison and mass icy prison;
- wall of ice, wall of force, and forcecage;
- control water and control weather;
- hydraulic torrent, geyser, and ice spears;

- greater dispel magic and mage's disjunction;
- greater teleport, teleportation circle, plane shift, and gate;
- seamantle, freedom of movement, mind blank, spell turning, emergency force sphere, and contingency.

Her water, cold, and weather magic should support both combat and fleet operations. Wandering Weather is especially relevant to the Dawnrunner's speed, while Aristea's shipboard role favors control effects that do not destroy hulls, rigging, cargo, or civilians.

Crafting and infrastructure

Aristea remains the party's primary crafter. Use her Crafting Mastery, Arcane Builder, Quick Study, high Intelligence, and the demiplane's accelerated time before buying additional crafting feats.

Priority projects are:

1. defensive and mobility items that preserve her action economy;
2. spell-resistance and concealment counters for the ray routine;
3. staves holding water/cold control and utility spells that are inefficient to prepare daily;
4. permanent teleportation and demiplane infrastructure;
5. ship improvements that exploit magical propulsion, weather control, repairs, and safe navigation.

Confirm how the three-times-speed demiplane handles rest, outside deadlines, material delivery, and crafting-day limits before using it in production estimates.

Epic spell priorities

Epic spells require the campaign's approved level-10/11 slot and learning table. The initial order remains:

Level-10 candidates

1. Enchant Item.
2. Master Finished Work I.
3. Create Gate or Teleport Circle.
4. Perfect Resurrection after a soul is free.
5. Cloak of the Gods.
6. Epic Shadow Evocation if its reconstructed text is approved.

Level-11 candidates

1. Master Finished Work II.
2. Enchant Item II.
3. Epic Dispel Magic.
4. Absorb Energy.
5. Epic Particulate Form.
6. Create Roaming Hungry Pit.

Do not spend level-10/11 access merely on a larger ray unless it clearly exceeds the perfected scorching-ray routine or bypasses a defense that routine cannot defeat.

Level-by-level action plan

Level	Class and feat	Spell and tactical priority	Result
17	Current: Wizard 9 / Sorcerer 1 / Arcane Trickster 7	Recover soul; preserve current sheet and manual overrides	11d6 actual sneak attack
18	Arcane Trickster 8	Add time stop, shapechange, mass icy prison, wish	9th-level spells; 12d6 sneak attack
19	Arcane Trickster 9; Quicken Spell	Build quickened perfected-ray packages; exploit Invisible Thief for ordinary sneak attacks	Better action economy; Invisible Thief
20	Arcane Trickster 10	Use Surprise Spells against genuinely flat-footed targets	13d6 sneak attack; prestige capstone
21	Exploiter Wizard 10; Spell Penetration; legal metamagic bonus feat	Harden the ray against epic SR and add a control option	Effective Wizard casting 20
22	Exploiter Wizard 11	Expand control, escape, and naval preparation	Broader endurance
23	Exploiter Wizard 12; Greater Spell Penetration	Complete the spell-resistance package	Reliable delivery
24	Exploiter Wizard 13	Select the next exploit; prepare epic spell prerequisites	Flexible epic chassis
25	Exploiter Wizard 14; Seeking Spell if approved or epic prerequisite	Defeat concealment and cover or qualify for chosen epic magic	Completed first post-20 package

Combat doctrine

1. Enter dangerous areas with long-duration defenses active and a survival-focused contingency.
2. Use scouting and +41 initiative to attack before priority enemies act; this is the cleanest Sap Master trigger.
3. Have Demidius or another specialist identify and strip spell turning, concealment, immunity, and layered magical defenses.
4. Against a valid flat-footed target, deliver the Benthic/Merciful/Sap ray package and apply the artifact's additional 5d6 to every qualifying sneak attack under the campaign ruling.
5. If the target is only denied Dexterity but not flat-footed, apply ordinary sneak attack without doubling it through Sap Master.
6. If nonlethal or precision damage is ineffective, switch immediately to control, dispelling, force, disintegration, transformation, or naval battlefield manipulation.
7. Once Quicken Spell is acquired, avoid spending both the standard and swift spell on damage unless ending the encounter prevents a greater threat. Preserve an action or resource for defense when needed.

Decisions still requiring confirmation

- Does the GM have an epic Arcane Trickster 11+ table, and what continues after level 10?
- Does the campaign explicitly treat invisibility or Impromptu Sneak Attack as making a target flat-footed, or only as denying Dexterity?
- Does every scorching-ray ray continue to receive sneak attack under the current table ruling?
- Does the Benthic/Merciful ray continue to count as a bludgeoning weapon for Sap Adept and Sap Master?
- Does the artifact's +5d6 apply to every qualifying ray without a per-round limit?
- What is the exact text of the artifact's separate always-on Vital Strike-like effect?

- What mechanical abilities replace Hero Lab's shark-only Animal Lord entries for the sacred narwhal form?
- What is Aristea's current Mythic Tier after applying the campaign godly-power/path-power formula?
- Does Mythic Crafting Mastery remove the need for future item-creation feats in this campaign?
- Which epic casting table controls effective Wizard levels above 20?

Sources

- Current Aristea Hero Lab character sheet supplied 22 July 2026, especially pp. 1-4.
- Pathfinder Roleplaying Game Core Rulebook, Arcane Trickster table and class features, printed pp. 376-377.
- Pathfinder Roleplaying Game Ultimate Combat, Sap Adept and Sap Master, printed p. 116.
- Pathfinder Roleplaying Game Mythic Adventures, Archmage abilities, universal abilities, mythic feats, and mythic spells.
- Campaign rulings supplied by the player: multi-ray sneak attack, Benthic/Merciful/Sap interaction, artifact +5d6 sneak attack, free combat feats, Boon progression, and custom Mythic Tier/Power calculation.
- Aristea campaign biography and Nereus/Animal Lord of the Tides records.
- Epic Spell Compendium campaign transcription and reconstruction.